



The Representation Of Gender Inequality Toward Female Characters In Sasti Gotama's Novel Korpus Uterus: A Norman Fairclough Critical Discourse Analysis Perspective

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Article Info

Received: April 18, 2026
Revised: June 13, 2026
Accepted: July 06, 2026

Keywords:

Gender Inequality, Women,
Uterine Corpus, Sasti Gotama,
Norman Fairclough's Critical
Discourse Analysis

Abstract

Literature is a product of human thought that originates from individuals and derives from the surrounding social environment. The purpose of this study is to reveal the representation of gender inequality toward female characters in Sasti Gotama's novel *Korpus Uterus*. The focus of this study lies in three aspects, namely textual analysis, text interpretation, and text explanation. The data source of this study is the novel *Corpus Uterus* by Sasti Gotama. The data consists of excerpts in the form of phrases, clauses, words, and paragraphs found to be relevant within the novel. The data analysis technique employed in this study is descriptive qualitative analysis. Meanwhile, the data were collected through reading and note-taking techniques. This study adopts a qualitative approach. The findings indicate that, at the textual level, the novel employs diction closely associated with the medical field. This is inseparable from the author's professional background as a physician. In addition, the use of such objects is related to trauma, marginalization, and subordination, all of which signify forms of gender inequality. In terms of text production, the author utilizes her knowledge and professional background to deconstruct narratives of injustice that have long constrained women. Through this strategy, the author encourages readers not only to empathize with the characters' trauma but also to think critically about the experiences that surround them. Furthermore, the explanatory dimension of the text reflects the reality in Indonesia, where gender inequality experienced by women through patriarchal hegemony remains deeply entrenched and persistent.

To cite this article: Mayada, M., Hardinanto, E., & Faizi, A. (2026). The Representation of Gender Inequality Toward Female Characters In Sasti Gotama's Novel *Korpus Uterus*: A Norman Fairclough Critical Discourse Analysis Perspective. *Alinea: Jurnal Bahasa, Sastra Dan Pengajaran*, 6(2), 651–666. <https://doi.org/10.58218/alinea.v6i2.2719>.

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Introduction

Literature constitutes an inseparable part of the social structure of society. The existence of literature establishes interconnections among various elements within that structure. Literature plays a significant role in shaping the identity of a nation. Through literature, noble cultural values that remain embedded within society are preserved and transmitted. In line with this view, Mubarak et al. (2026) argue that the presence of literature gives rise to cultural values and customs that reinforce a nation's identity. Over time, literature continues to evolve in accordance with social and historical developments. Literature not only embodies the cultural characteristics possessed by a

nation but also becomes an attraction for foreign communities to study and investigate a nation's culture. Furthermore, literary works serve as an expressive medium through which authors articulate their ideas. Consistent with this perspective, Irmayanti et al. (2026) states that an author's tradition of expressing creative and imaginative ideas through literary works functions both as a manifestation of ideas and as a reflection of responses to the social dynamics developing within society.

The existence of literature is not merely a form of individual creativity imbued with aesthetic values derived from life. Nugraha (2022) asserts that literature is highly beneficial to human life because literary works provide readers with an awareness of life's truths, even when presented in fictional forms. However, literature also emerges as a response to power structures and everyday social practices. This indicates that literature is always connected to the surrounding environment as a product of its creation. This view is supported by Rismayanti et al. (2020), who emphasizes that the emergence of literary works cannot be separated from the social context of their existence, as they are invariably linked to the historical, cultural, and social conditions that surround them. Literature functions as a means of amplifying social realities that continue to constitute unresolved problems. One of the most crucial issues that remains widely debated is the position of women. Women frequently become victims of unequal power relations between themselves and men. Women's issues continue to represent an important and compelling subject of discussion. In this regard, Shubhi et al. (2025) argue that women still confront various conditions that marginalize their position within society. Moreover, such circumstances encourage women to become more empowered in their struggle to attain equal rights. Women are often treated as objects of male exploitation. If one examines the history of women's struggles, or feminism, it becomes apparent that these efforts are not a recent phenomenon. Rather, this long history of struggle began as early as the eighteenth century in the United States.

Wiyatmi (2012) states that the feminist movement is often characterized as a radical struggle. This radical struggle focuses on the roots of oppression originating from patriarchal ideology, which continues to constrain women. Women are frequently regarded as unsuitable for participation in the public sphere, while their presence is considered more appropriate within the domestic domain. This argument is reinforced by Islahuddin et al. (2021), who contend that the culture of oppressing women constitutes one of the primary factors contributing to gender inequality. In this context, gender refers to the dominance of particular characteristics attributed to men and women through social and cultural construction. Furthermore, Sugihastuti and Sastriyani (2007) argue that gender becomes the source of inequality affecting either men or women when harmonious relations between the two are absent. Fakhri (1997) defines gender as a set of characteristics attributed to women and men through cultural and social constructions. For example, women are commonly associated with traits such as gentleness and maternal qualities, whereas men are more frequently described as strong, rational, courageous, and masculine.

The representation of women in literary texts provides a pathway for examining women's issues, which remain unresolved. In this context, literature functions as a space that facilitates women's voices, which are often silenced by prevailing social constructions. Yunarti et al. (2025) emphasize that feminism in literature plays a role in revealing the representation of women as well as forms of gender inequality that frequently appear in various narratives. In addition, themes related to women's inequality, such as marginalization, subordination, stereotyping, and the

confinement of women to the domestic sphere, reflect patriarchal norms that restrict women's autonomy and social mobility. Thus, feminism within literary studies does not merely function as a tool for criticizing systems that oppress women but also serves as a means of representing women in a more equitable and diverse manner. Shofiani (2022) argues that feminist scholarship directs its analytical focus toward women. This demonstrates that feminist literature seeks to cultivate awareness of how gender influences life, culture, and literature. Moreover, Hardinanto (2025) adds that literature, as part of discursive practices within society, functions as a means of constructing or transforming ideology. As a result, literary creation cannot be separated from language as one of its fundamental constituent elements.

The creation of a literary work is closely related to the author's ideology in expressing ideas and perspectives. This relationship forms a complex network interconnected with various discourses. In line with this view, Windiatmoko (2017) asserts that discourse refers to a complete and complex linguistic entity. Because discourse is practical and rational in nature, numerous analytical tools can be employed to examine it. The purpose of discourse is to provide language users with a framework for understanding and employing language appropriately and effectively. In literary texts, discourse serves as a means of uncovering the author's ideology embedded within the construction of the work. Roni et al. (2025) similarly argue that discourse, as an integral component of language, functions as a primary medium for conveying meaning, shaping perceptions, and negotiating power within society. Language does not merely represent reality; Rather, it also functions as a tool for constructing ideology and social reality. Burke (1973) further argued that literary works are products of thought and experience derived from several factors: (1) responding to ideology and the prevailing political climate; (2) establishing relational links concerning the complex relationship between ideology and the modes of literary production; (3) explaining ideology within a particular historical period; (4) clarifying the interconnections among aesthetic, moral, and social inquiries; and (5) positioning ideology as a political stance.

Departing from the arguments advanced by previous scholars, language, through the framework of Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA), emerges as an approach that positions language as a social practice imbued with power relations, ideological values, and particular social interests. This approach maintains that every linguistic utterance constitutes a political act aimed either at sustaining or challenging deviant social structures. In other words, language functions as a form of critique toward phenomena considered incompatible with prevailing social institutions. In this context, CDA is regarded as important because it can uncover the hidden ideologies underlying textual production, creating social identities, and constructing forms of resistance through discourse. The significance of Critical Discourse Analysis also lies in its role as an analytical tool that connects a critical approach with the investigation of hidden ideological forces through the representation of language. Hardinanto (2025) argues that ideology constitutes the central concept in any critical analysis. Therefore, discourse possesses the capacity to manipulate or influence readers toward particular ideological positions. Darma (2009) further contends that discourse may be understood as a manifestation of ideology and a reflection of specific ideological orientations.

Literary works constitute representations of everyday life. Wellek and Warren (2014) further assert that literary works refer to reflections of social life, which serves as a source of conflicts viewed as social phenomena. Andani et al. (2022) argue that although literary works are derived

from surrounding realities, their formation cannot be separated from the fictional imagination of the author. Furthermore, the diverse forms of literature, particularly novels as written literary works, constitute crucial objects for examination through the lens of CDA. As written texts, novels function as reflections of the social realities that exist within society. Controversies presented in novels frequently represent characters, ideological tensions, and struggles over identity. In this regard, Rahmayanti et al. (2025) state that novels are inseparable from the controversial elements they raise, whether in terms of themes, characters, or the extrinsic aspects of a narrative. From this perspective, it may be concluded that the novel serves as a discursive space that integrates narrative, dialogue, plot, and character representation in articulating ideologies and power relations. Therefore, Fairclough's perspective enables readers to critically challenge symbolic structures embedded within literary texts and to examine the construction of social orders derived from surrounding realities.

The diversity of literary genres in Indonesia, particularly the novel, has led the researcher into a feminist domain that continues to attract scholarly attention. In this study, the researcher examines the recently published novel *Korpus Uterus* by Sasti Gotama. *Korpus Uterus* was published in 2025 by an author with a professional background in the medical field. The novel emerged from the experiences of a writer who practices as a physician. Given the apparent contrast between her medical career and literary endeavors, the novel raises numerous ideas and issues concerning the politics of women's bodies. Sasti Gotama is able to dissect various dimensions of womanhood through a medical perspective that remains unfamiliar to many readers. She foregrounds feminist concerns by integrating them with issues of health, a theme closely related to her profession as a doctor. The novel *Korpus Uterus* narrates the experiences of women who become victims of violence and eventually choose abortion as a path through which to confront their circumstances.

The researcher selected this novel because it provides an opportunity to uncover issues of gender inequality experienced by women. These issues encompass bodily organs, female anatomy, patriarchal power relations, and various forms of inequality that have long been normalized in everyday life. In addition, the researcher seeks to examine every textual element within the novel in order to uncover silenced voices that have been marginalized within dominant discourses. The author combines anatomical language with aesthetic literary expression as a form of respect for the female body, which has often been reduced to a mere biological function. In *Korpus Uterus*, the female body becomes the site of exploitation and suffering. The representation of women in Sasti Gotama's *Korpus Uterus* constitutes a compelling subject for discussion because it depicts women who experience discrimination while simultaneously struggling against injustice and pursuing the freedom that has long been denied to them. The researcher intensively connects the issues presented in the novel with Fairclough's Critical Discourse Analysis, thereby establishing a meaningful meaningful correlation between the literary work and the theoretical framework employed in this study.

Critical Discourse Analysis is viewed as a tool for advocating on behalf of those who are oppressed, subordinated, hegemonized, and socially determined by dominant structures. This perspective arises from the awareness that marginalized communities often experience powerlessness in the face of dominant public discourses. Santoso (2015) emphasizes that analysis should serve to empower oppressed communities. Furthermore, numerous scholars have argued that the analysis of social issues in discourse requires a critical paradigm rather than a merely

descriptive one that only presents phenomena without questioning their underlying structures. The orientation of Critical Discourse Analysis toward external social phenomena is rooted in Fairclough's work *Critical Discourse Analysis*, which combines the tradition of textual analysis with broader societal contexts. Language, as a manifestation of text, is viewed as existing within a dialectical relationship with social structures. Consequently, analysis focuses on language as both shaped by and shaping social relations and specific social contexts. Hardinanto and Raharjo (2022) argue that Critical Discourse Analysis functions as a channel through which women's voices can be articulated, particularly when those voices have long been constrained by patriarchal domination within the domestic sphere. This perspective assumes that discursive practices can reveal the effects of particular beliefs and ideologies. The contextual dimension of discourse concerns the ways in which language is employed to achieve certain objectives and practices, including the exercise of power. According to it, the fundamental premise of Critical Discourse Analysis is that discourse should not be understood merely as an object of linguistic study but also as a means of analyzing texts within their broader social and ideological contexts.

Norman Fairclough developed a discourse analysis model that makes a significant contribution by combining textuality with broader social contexts that extend beyond closed textual spaces. This model was designed to integrate discourse analysis grounded in linguistics with the study of social change. The use of discourse refers to the use of language as a social practice that carries implications far more meaningful than merely reflecting individual activities or representing particular phenomena. Therefore, discourse constitutes a form of action through which individuals employ language as a means of engaging with the world and representing existing realities. This model further implies a reciprocal relationship between discourse and social structures. Fairclough, as cited in Badara (2012), classifies Critical Discourse Analysis into three dimensions: text description, text interpretation, and text explanation. Each of these dimensions performs a distinct role within the analytical framework while simultaneously establishing interconnected relationships with one another.

Norman Fairclough also categorizes the three dimensions of his discourse analysis into a framework that is both simple and complex. These dimensions consist of text, discourse practice, and social practice. The text dimension is concerned with linguistic aspects, such as vocabulary, semantics, sentence structure, coherence, and cohesion, as well as the ways in which these elements collectively construct meaning. Discourse practice refers to the dimensions associated with the processes of text production and consumption. Social practice, meanwhile, concerns contexts beyond the text itself, including situational contexts or media contexts in relation to society and particular political cultures. Within the dimension of social practice, Fairclough (1989, p. 163) emphasizes two aspects that must be analyzed, namely determinants and effects. Determinants refer to power relations that shape discourse within processes of social struggle. Effects, on the other hand, refer to the consequences produced by discourse. Both determinants and effects must be examined across three levels of social organization: the social level, the institutional level, and the situational level.

Based on the foregoing explanation, Critical Discourse Analysis may be defined as an in-depth study that seeks to uncover activities, perspectives, and identities through the language employed within discourse. Critical Discourse Analysis using Fairclough's model demonstrates the

integration of: (a) text analysis; (b) analysis of the processes of text production, consumption, and distribution; and (c) analysis of the sociocultural conditions surrounding the discourse. These three forms of analysis constitute an inseparable whole. This understanding suggests that conducting an in-depth analysis of a text or discourse requires examining it comprehensively rather than partially. Within the sociocultural dimension, it becomes evident that texts are influenced and shaped by sociocultural conditions, including situational contexts, institutional contexts, and processes of social change.

A research study cannot be separated from previous relevant studies that provide logical connections through similarities in data sources, analytical frameworks, or other related aspects. The relevant studies considered in this research consist of several scholarly articles written by different authors. First, a study conducted by Putri and Putri (2023) sought to reveal women's voices in two short stories written by Sasti Gotama through a literary text analysis approach. The findings indicated that: (1) the short stories "Apa yang Paul McCartney Bisikkan Kepada Janitra?" and "Pembersih Jejak Kematian" depict women's voices through experiences as mothers and wives within domestic life, as represented by the female protagonists Janitra and Hantu Rain; and (2) the analysis demonstrated that women's voices in these short stories advocate justice in the form of appreciation, recognition, and proper understanding of their efforts and sacrifices as mothers and wives within their families. The similarities between that study and the present research lie in the discussion of women's issues. However, the difference between the study conducted by Putri and Putri (2023) and the present research lies in the theoretical framework employed, Critical Discourse Analysis.

Second, a study conducted by Saragih et al. (2025) analyzed language style and educational values in Sasti Gotama's novel "Ingatan Ikan-Ikan," while also examining contemporary literature as a medium for transmitting moral and social values. The findings revealed that: (1) the novel employs significant variations of figurative language, including metaphor, symbolism, paradox, oxymoron, and litotes, which strengthen the emotional expression of the characters; and (2) the novel contains character educational values such as religiosity, hard work, and social concerns as reflected through the actions of its characters. The difference between the studies conducted by Saragih et al. (2025) and the present research lies in the theoretical framework employed. The similarity between the two studies is that both examine literary works written by the same author, Sasti Gotama. Meanwhile, the differences lie in the linguistic focus adopted as well as the educational values explored within the novel.

Third, a study conducted by Arifah and Indriyani (2023) sought to explore the forms of anxiety that influence the behavior, emotional reactions, and internalized experiences within the subconscious mind of the character Lian. The findings revealed that the traumatic experiences endured by Lian significantly affected an individual's mental condition in the form of anxiety that persists into adulthood. The similarity between this study and the present research lies in the literary works written by Sasti Gotama that serve as the object of analysis, particularly *Ingatan Ikan-Ikan*. However, the study by Arifah and Indriyani (2023) examined only a single novel. The difference between their study and the present research lies in the theoretical framework employed. Arifah and Indriyani (2023) utilized Sigmund Freud's literary psychology approach, whereas the present study employs Critical Discourse Analysis as its theoretical framework and focuses on the novel "Korpus Uterus."

Fourth, a study conducted by Suharyo and Prapaskah (2025) aimed to construct the traumatic experiences endured by Chinese women in the aftermath of the May 1998 tragedy. The findings demonstrated that Chinese women experienced profound trauma and became victims of violence. The study conducted by Suharyo and Prapaskah (2025) shares several similarities with the present research, one of which is the discussion of a novel by Sasti Gotama, "Ingatan Ikan-Ikan." However, the distinction lies in the focus of the analysis. Their study specifically examines the discrimination experienced by female characters in its entirety within Sasti Gotama's novel. The female protagonists in the novels under discussion are similarly portrayed as victims of discrimination, although they experience different forms and backgrounds of violence.

Drawing upon the studies conducted by Putri and Putri (2023), Saragih et al. (2025), Arifah and Indriyani (2023), and Suharyo and Prapaskah (2025), this research seeks to examine the manifestations of gender inequality experienced by women in Sasti Gotama's novel *Korpus Uterus*. The novel represents the condition of women who have long been subjected to various forms of gender-based injustice. These issues are presented in a concise yet explicit manner throughout the narrative. To investigate these issues more comprehensively, the present study employs Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA) as its analytical framework in order to explore the literary text in a deeper and more critical manner. This consideration strengthens the researcher's interest in examining the selected object of study more intensively, particularly because none of the previously mentioned studies has investigated the same object using the same theoretical framework. Consequently, this research is expected to contribute a novel perspective to future scholarly discussions.

Materials and Methods

This study employed a critical descriptive qualitative research method. The analytical approach used in this study was Fairclough's Critical Discourse Analysis. The data source consisted of the novel "Korpus Uterus" by Sasti Gotama. The data analyzed in this study were excerpts in the form of phrases, clauses, words, and paragraphs that were found to be relevant to the research focus. The data collection technique employed in this study was the document analysis technique, also referred to as the library research technique. This document analysis was accompanied by activities of reading and recording textual excerpts from the novel, followed by classifying and marking data that were considered relevant to the research objectives. The data analysis technique utilized in this study was qualitative data analysis. To ensure the validity of the data, the researcher employed triangulation.

Results And Discussion

This study presents a Critical Discourse Analysis of the literary work *Korpus Uterus* by Sasti Gotama. *Korpus Uterus* is a recently published novel released in 2025. The novel is analyzed through a reconstructive approach that places ideology and ideological analysis at the center of the investigation. As explained in the previous section, Fairclough's Critical Discourse Analysis encompasses three social dimensions: the textual dimension, discursive practice, and sociocultural practice. *Korpus Uterus* emerged from the intellectual and creative vision of an author whose professional background is in medicine. Drawing from both her medical career and literary endeavors, Sasti Gotama raises numerous ideas and issues concerning the politics of women's bodies. She is able to examine various dimensions of womanhood through a medical perspective that remains

unfamiliar to many readers. Furthermore, Sasti Gotama highlights women's voices that have long been overlooked by integrating them with issues of health, a theme closely related to her profession as a physician.

The novel *Korpus Uterus* tells the story of a woman who becomes a victim of violence and eventually chooses abortion as a path through which to confront her circumstances. The story begins during the early period associated with the political upheavals of 1965 and centers on a woman named Kalimah, the wife of a poet. Her husband, Hafidhin, is a member of the Institute of People's Culture (Lekra). Kalimah becomes a victim of sexual violence perpetrated by state authorities. She is repeatedly raped by members of an elite group who regard her husband as their enemy. The events originate from Hafidhin's opposition to government policies. As a poet, Hafidhin frequently composed verses that strongly criticized government regulations and political practices. As a consequence, he became a target of persecution and surveillance by those in power. Kalimah, who was unaware of the nature of her husband's activities and political involvement, ultimately became a victim of the government's tyranny directed against her family.

As time progresses, the narrative highlights the events of 1965, particularly the tragedy of the September 30th Movement, which was marked by the abduction and killing of several high-ranking Army officers at Lubang Buaya. The Indonesian Communist Party (Partai Komunis Indonesia or PKI), which at the time was one of the largest communist parties in the world, was accused of orchestrating the incident. This period also marked the rise of Suharto's military power, supported by civilian forces. Massive campaigns of indoctrination emerged, targeting individuals who were affiliated with or sympathetic to communist groups. Subsequently, numerous cases of rape, abduction, and mass killings carried out by the state became part of the dark political crisis of the period. As a result, the government implemented policies aimed at arresting activists whose existence was perceived as a threat to the state.

Sasti Gotama's *Korpus Uterus* opens a discursive space for exploring reproductive trauma. Through the character of Kalimah, who becomes a victim of state-sponsored sexual violence, the novel depicts the experience of enduring lifelong trauma. Kalimah undertakes an action that has long been considered socially unacceptable. She chooses to terminate an unwanted pregnancy through abortion. However, Kalimah's life is overshadowed by profound suffering, as her attempt to abort the fetus proves unsuccessful. As a result, she eventually gives birth to a child she never wanted to conceive.

Women's bodies are often treated as subjects surrounded by social taboos. *Korpus Uterus* presents a dark historical narrative marked by trauma resulting from miscarriage and inhumane medical procedures that endanger women's lives. The female body is depicted as a silent witness to both mental and physical suffering passed down from a mother to her child. Yet, as similar events continue to recur over time, these experiences gradually fade from public memory. History conceals the suffering of women who have repeatedly been subdued by social structures. Through *Korpus Uterus*, the female body becomes a repository of painful secrets, where memory, suffering, surgery, and violence serve as central elements of the narrative.

The narrative overview presented above serves as an introduction to the present study, which seeks to examine the novel intensively through the interconnected dimensions of text, discursive practice, and sociocultural practice.

Textual Dimensions

Based on the vocabulary employed in **Korpus Uterus**, the author constructs the central themes of the novel while simultaneously depicting relations of power, ideology, and social norms embedded within the text. The following are several lexical choices that frequently appear throughout the novel.

Table 1.
Lexical Choices

No.	Lexical Items
1.	Corpus
2.	Uterus
3.	Fetus
4.	Jar
5.	The Desire to Return to the Womb

Based on Table 1, it can be observed that, from a lexical perspective, the themes presented in the novel are closely related to the author's professional background. The author's involvement in the medical field contributes to the vivid portrayal of women's experiences, which are framed through medical terminology. According to the Large Indonesian Dictionary (KBBI), the lexical item *korpus* (*corpus*) refers to the human body, while *uterus* refers to the womb. When these two lexical items are combined into the phrase *Korpus Uterus*, they literally signify the “body of the womb” or “human womb.” More precisely, however, the phrase refers to the human uterus possessed by every woman. As the title of the novel, *Korpus Uterus* provides readers with an indication that the narrative addresses the female body, particularly a body that has long been deprived of authority over itself. Women's bodies, especially the uterus, are often not fully controlled by women themselves. Various pressures stemming from social norms, religious values, and even state intervention often compel women to continue pregnancies and give birth despite circumstances in which such outcomes are not desired.

Through this novel, the author articulates an ideology that critiques the tendency to define women primarily through their reproductive functions, as though reproduction was the sole determinant of an individual's value. Furthermore, as an author with a professional background in medicine, Sasti Gotama demonstrates that medical institutions can at times become instruments of repression against women when they are not accompanied by empathy and respect for women's bodily autonomy. Another lexical item that reinforces the novel's thematic concerns is the word *fetus*. According to the KBBI, the lexical meaning of *janin* (*fetus*) refers to the embryonic entity enclosed within the membrane of the womb where a baby develops. However, metaphorically, the word *fetus* is employed throughout the novel to convey a number of deeper meanings.

In *Korpus Uterus*, the fetus symbolizes past trauma and secrets carried by female characters. Sasti Gotama frequently explores the idea that women's bodies preserve painful collective memories from the past. The fetus is depicted as a part of the human body that remains incomplete and immature yet continues to grow. When its presence is unwanted, it may become a source of psychological distress for women. Through the narrative of the fetus, the author challenges structures that have historically silenced women's authority over their own bodies. Within society,

family expectations, social systems, and medical procedures often intervene in matters that should belong to women's personal and private spheres. Moreover, the fetus is metaphorically represented as a reproductive burden that often becomes a source of suffering rather than happiness for women.

Another lexical item that strengthens the central theme of the novel is the word jar (toples). According to the KBBI, a toples is defined as a closed glass container commonly used to store objects. However, behind this seemingly ordinary object lies a profound symbolic meaning that encapsulates one of the novel's central themes. The jar represents a confined space in which women are expected to be "preserved." The notion of being "preserved" refers to a space for storing organs, memories, and even women's identities. This symbolism suggests that patriarchal systems and social expectations force women into rigid, static, and restrictive structures that limit their freedom of movement. Furthermore, the transparent nature of the jar symbolizes a condition in which women constantly become objects of observation, judgment, and criticism without being granted full rights to privacy or autonomy. This symbolism is reflected in the following excerpt.

"Dokter Markus kerap memandang dengan sayang rahim yang melayang-layang di samping tempat tidurnya. Gurat-gurat otot itulah yang melindunginya dari benturan luar dan mengayun-ayunnya dalam hangat ketuban." (Gotama, 2025: 112) ("Doctor Markus often gazed affectionately at the uterus floating beside his bed. Its muscular layers protected it from external impacts and gently rocked it within the warmth of the amniotic fluid." (Gotama, 2025: 112)

The excerpt above indicates that the uterus appears to be suspended or floating within a container resembling a jar. Symbolically, this image suggests that women are preserved within a narrow space where trauma and memories of the past remain intact. Although such preservation may maintain those memories, it simultaneously prevents women from continuing to grow, recover, or heal. Consequently, the jar symbolizes the powerlessness of women who are isolated and confined by circumstances beyond their control.

Another dominant lexical expression in *Korpus Uterus* is the phrase "returning to the womb." This phrase conveys a particularly powerful meaning. Sasti Gotama employs this metaphor not merely to signify a physical movement back into an enclosed space but rather as a symbol of a dark psychological and existential journey. The womb is depicted as a place of shelter, safety, and warmth, free from demands and expectations. Metaphorically, the phrase "returning to the womb" reflects the desire of female characters to escape from an external world that is cruel, oppressive, and deeply traumatic. It represents a form of emotional regression, revealing the lowest point of suffering and anguish experienced by women. Furthermore, the phrase may also be interpreted as expressing the desire of the fetus within the womb never to be born. The increasingly unsafe conditions faced by women in the outside world render their existence and freedom of movement highly restricted. In a broader sense, the phrase "returning to the womb" functions as a form of resistance against the external world, reflecting women's exhaustion from continuously confronting social structures that objectify their bodies. This is illustrated in the following excerpt.

"Tak ada yang lebih diinginkan Luh selain kembali ke rahim. Pemerksaan yang berulang kali berusaha digugurkan, Luh merasa dunia fana ini begitu kejam. Tak ada

kasih sayang dari ibunya. Dia dipelihara bagai hewan ternak yang cukup diberi makan tiga kali sehari.” (Gotama, 2025: 29) (“There was nothing Luh desired more than returning to the womb. Conceived through a rape that had repeatedly been subjected to attempts at abortion, Luh perceived this mortal world as profoundly cruel. She received no affection from her mother. She was raised like livestock, provided with nothing more than three meals a day.” (Gotama, 2025, 2025: 29)

The excerpt above demonstrates that the word rape (pemeriksaan), which is closely connected to the data under discussion, highlights the fragility of justice for marginalized groups. Women are frequently colonized and exploited by external expectations imposed upon them. In this regard, the author positions literature as a space through which women may reclaim narratives that rightfully belong to them but have long been silenced by the repressive force of conventional norms. Through the publication of this novel, Sasti Gotama attempts to liberate that silenced space and restore women's voices within it.

Discursive Practice Dimension (Text Interpretation)

In the novel *Korpus Uterus*, the author develops a critical discourse and an ideologically progressive narrative of resistance. The author's resistance to prevailing social stigmas is centered on progressive feminism, which emphasizes reproductive rights and the elimination of social stigmatization. Women are frequently confronted with difficult choices, even when those choices are regarded as taboo within society. The female body is often perceived as a battleground, and ownership over it is considered to belong not solely to the individual woman herself but also to the surrounding social environment that continually intervenes in matters concerning her body.

In this novel, the author critically explores and scrutinizes the realities of Indonesia during the 1965 period. The character Kalimah becomes a victim of rape perpetrated by state authorities as a consequence of political accusations. This circumstance may also be interpreted as demonstrating how women's bodies can become sites of struggle within the context of political conflict. Consider the following excerpt.

*“Kalimah ditelentangkan. Dingin ubin terasa menggigit punggungnya. Dua tangannya ditahan di atas kepala oleh satu orang dan dua kakinya dipegang oleh dua orang lain.”
“Kalimah was laid flat on her back. The cold floor tiles bit into her skin. One man restrained her hands above her head while two others held her legs.”*

“Kembali Kalimah mendengar bunyi kres-kres, tapi kali ini dari bagian bawah tubuhnya. Bunyi itu diselingi rasa nyeri ketika kulit kelaminnya beberapa kali tergores.” (Gotama, 2025: 20) “Once again, Kalimah heard a scraping sound, but this time it came from the lower part of her body. The sound was accompanied by pain as the skin around her genitals was repeatedly scratched.” (Gotama, 2025: 20)

Through this excerpt, the author invites readers to examine more deeply the experience of Kalimah as a victim of sexual violence committed by state officials. More tragically, as time passes, no one is able to provide justice for the violence she endured. The narrative suggests a world that consistently sides with those who possess power and authority. Marginalized groups are frequently

deprived of both a voice and justice in response to the suffering they experience. This condition is further illustrated in the following excerpt.

"Namun, itu tidaklah mudah. Terkadang ia kembali menjadi manusia dan jarinya gemetar sehingga tak mampu menekan tombol mesin tik. Suara gunting, cukur, jeritan, dan tawa laki-laki bergema di kepalanya. Yang tercium hanyalah aroma tahi. Ketika itu terjadi, dia segera menengok tato di lengan kanannya supaya dia ingat dirinya bukan manusia, dia adalah sulur kacang panjang yang tak punya rasa." (Gotama, 2025: 27). "Yet it was not easy. At times she became human again, and her fingers trembled so violently that she could no longer press the keys of the typewriter. The sounds of scissors, razors, screams, and men's laughter echoed through her mind. All she could smell was the stench of excrement. Whenever this happened, she would immediately look at the tattoo on her right arm to remind herself that she was not human; she was a tendril of a yardlong bean, incapable of feeling." (Gotama, 2025: 27)

The phrase "a tendril of a yardlong bean" in the excerpt above depicts a problematic representation of reproduction and bodily experience. However, this representation is framed through a metaphorical language that appears deceptively ordinary. In this novel, the author employs the word tendril to signify something that creeps, clings, or entwines itself around other objects. Meanwhile, the yardlong bean is commonly associated with vegetables and, symbolically, with the domestic sphere traditionally assigned to women. When combined into a single phrase, the metaphor appears to encourage readers to reconsider forms of gender inequality that have long been normalized or trivialized, whether within social structures or domestic settings. Furthermore, the metaphor of a creeping plant or bean tendril creates an image of something that continuously coils and entangles itself, remaining uncontrollable and deeply tormenting.

The use of the image of an entwining tendril symbolizes physical suffering that society often normalizes despite its profound consequences. Such suffering may be understood as an actualization of psychological and social repression. Through the use of a vegetable-associated image such as the yardlong bean, the author invites readers to recognize how women's bodies have historically been treated as commodities to be shaped, controlled, and utilized according to the desires of others, particularly within patriarchal structures. The representation of the female body as a discourse of power can be observed through women's powerlessness in confronting the difficult circumstances imposed upon them. Rape and dissociation emerge as extreme manifestations of masculine control over women's bodies. Consequently, the medical terminology and symbolic imagery employed throughout the novel function not merely as references to biological realities but as representations of a contested arena where law, power, and violence intersect.

Text Explanation Dimension

This dimension focuses on the correlation between social struggles and the discourses that they shape. This is because texts and social structures are negotiated through the social context in which discourse operates. **Korpus Uterus** was written by an author who is deeply concerned about the dangers of illegal abortion and the threats it poses to women's safety. In addition, gender-based violence and the trauma associated with the events of 1965 served as important motivations behind

the creation of this novel. Women's bodies are frequently positioned as targets of violence and as sites of intergenerational trauma. This is illustrated in the following excerpt.

*"Ndak, saya sudah akad, lalu diceraikan. Apa yang dilakukan dalam pernikahan itu halal."
"No, I was legally married and then divorced. Whatever was done within that marriage was lawful."*

"Babi yang disembelih dengan nama Tuhan tak menjadikannya halal. Lagi pula, memangnya kamu tak memikirkan masa idah?" "A pig slaughtered in the name of God does not become lawful. Besides, have you not considered the waiting period (iddah)?"

"Bukannya aturan masa idah itu agar perempuan tahu siapa ayah bayi dalam kandungannya seandainya dia bercerai? Kalau saya pakai pil ya ndak perlu nunggu masa idah." (Gotama, 2025: 48) "Isn't the purpose of the iddah period to ensure that a woman knows the father of the child in her womb in the event of a divorce? If I use contraceptive pills, then there is no need to wait through the iddah period." (Gotama, 2025: 48)

The excerpt above demonstrates how Sasti Gotama constructs the narrative to explore women's bodies, which have long been expected to conform to religious prescriptions and societal norms. Through her work, the author invites readers to critically reexamine these assumptions by employing literature as a tool of intellectual emancipation. Readers are encouraged to question norms that have often been accepted as natural or inherent when, in reality, they are products of social construction. Through this novel, the author exposes forms of injustice by portraying the suffering experienced by female characters, not as a consequence of biological weakness but rather as the result of oppressive social structures.

The author's ideology seeks to transform readers' consciousness by encouraging them to view women not merely as objects but as subjects possessing full bodily autonomy and sovereignty. This explanatory dimension reveals that injustice begins to emerge when women lose the ability to exercise agency and decision-making power over their own bodies. Women's bodies are continuously subjected to intervention through medical policies and repression originating from family and social environments. This condition is reflected in the following excerpt.

"Tabu untuk perempuan bahwa dia membutuhkan itu. Moral mengharap perempuan sebagai tanah subur yang pasif, mengharapkan siraman benih tanpa hasrat. Karena bila dia menunjukkan itu dia dianggap binal. Padahal, bagi saya itu seperti air. Tanpa air, manusia akan dehidrasi dan mati. Memang, apa salahnya perempuan mengakui bahwa itu adalah kebutuhan, sebagaimana lelaki bisa leluasa mengucapkannya?" (Gotama, 2025: 165) "It is considered taboo for a woman to admit that she needs it. Morality expects women to be passive fertile soil, waiting for seeds to be sown without desire. If a woman expresses such desire, she is labeled promiscuous. Yet to me, it is like water. Without water, human beings would become dehydrated and die. What is wrong with women acknowledging that it is a need, just as men are free to express it openly?" (Gotama, 2025: 165)

The excerpt suggests that morality is often constructed from the perspective of those who possess social privilege. However, the circumstances faced by women living in poverty are markedly different. For many women, the body becomes one of the few forms of capital that can be

exchanged in order to secure survival. Economic vulnerability, the loss of bargaining power, and the urgency of fulfilling basic needs may compel women to enter relationships that are socially stigmatized. One example is cohabitation outside marriage, historically referred to in certain contexts as *koempoel gebouw*. This situation generates a toxic cycle in which women are morally condemned by society for engaging in non-marital cohabitation (*kumpul kebo*), while that same society fails to provide viable alternatives for achieving a dignified standard of living.

The explanatory dimension further demonstrates that although non-marital cohabitation (*kumpul kebo*) involves both partners, women disproportionately bear the social burden and negative labeling associated with such relationships. By presenting this phenomenon, the author seeks to advocate for the voices of marginalized women in Indonesia. The novel highlights how women's bodies are frequently treated as commodities that can be utilized in exchange for economic survival, while simultaneously being denied equal legal and social protection. Through this critique, *Korpus Uterus* exposes the persistent inequalities that continue to shape women's lives within contemporary society.

Conclusions

Based on the analysis of the literary text in Sasti Gotama's *Korpus Uterus*, it can be concluded that uncovering the ideology embedded within discourse requires the examination of three interconnected dimensions. Ideology cannot be understood by viewing language solely from a closed and isolated perspective; rather, it is necessary to consider the broader context, including the ideologies of the communities and social groups that contribute to the construction of discourse within a text. Furthermore, literary texts are closely related to the background of their authors, as an author's experiences and professional background influence the creation of literary works. From a textual perspective, the novel employs lexical choices closely associated with the medical field. The use of such terminology is related to themes of trauma, marginalization, and subordination, all of which reflect manifestations of gender inequality. In terms of text production, the author draws upon her professional knowledge and experiences to deconstruct patriarchal narratives that continue to constrain women. Through this strategy, the author encourages readers not merely to empathize with the characters but also to critically reflect upon the trauma that shapes their lives. From the perspective of text explanation, the novel reflects the social reality of Indonesia, where patriarchal hegemony remains deeply entrenched and continues to exert a powerful influence on women's lives.

Declaration of Conflicting Interest

There is no conflict of interest concerning the publication of this paper.

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